

Nookix Book Summary

Just Mercy Summary

by Bryan Stevenson

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Book Overview: Justice and Mercy in a Broken System

Bryan Stevenson was twenty-three years old when he walked onto death row for the first time. It was 1983, and he was a student at Harvard Law School, working as an intern for the Southern Prisoners Defense Committee in Georgia. He had grown up in a poor, rural, racially segregated settlement in Delaware, raised by a grandmother who was the daughter of former slaves. She told him something he never forgot: "You can't understand most of the important things from a distance, Bryan. You have to get close."

So there he was, getting close. A death row prisoner named Henry had been told he wouldn't receive an execution date for at least another year, and Stevenson was sent to deliver the news. He was nervous. He had never met a man on death row before. But Henry greeted him with joy, overjoyed to hear he would live another year. They spent three hours together, talking about everything—the case, their lives, the world outside those walls.

Stevenson had overstayed the visiting hours. The prison guards were annoyed. As they roughly took Henry away, something unexpected happened. Henry began to sing. The hymn was "Higher Ground," a Christian song Stevenson knew well from childhood Sundays in church. The lyrics speak of climbing toward something better, ascending to a place beyond reach. As Henry's voice filled the corridor, Stevenson felt something shift inside him. "In that moment," he would later write, "Henry altered my understanding of human potential, redemption, and hopefulness."

That single moment of grace—a condemned man singing as he was dragged back to his cell—reshaped everything. Stevenson realized that each person is more than the worst thing they have done. Even a man sentenced to death could rise to "higher ground." This became the foundation of his life's work.

After graduating Harvard, Stevenson founded the Equal Justice Initiative in Alabama, a nonprofit law organization dedicated to defending the poor, the wrongly convicted, and those trapped in a broken legal system. The state he chose was no accident. Alabama has one of the highest execution rates in the country, and almost all of those executed are men. Most are Black. The prison population in the United States had exploded from 300,000 to 2.3 million between the 1970s and 2014, with Black and Hispanic people making up 58 percent of those incarcerated. The War on Drugs and "Tough on Crime" policies had created a new caste system, targeting the poor, people of color, juveniles, women, and the mentally ill.

This book, *Just Mercy*, weaves together Stevenson's personal stories with a systemic critique of mass incarceration and the death penalty. At its center is the case of Walter McMillian, a Black man from Monroeville, Alabama—the same town where Harper Lee set *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Walter was wrongfully convicted of murdering a white woman, Ronda Morrison, in 1986. There was no evidence against him except that he was a Black man involved in an adulterous interracial affair. The local sheriff, a proud racist named Tom Tate, pressured witnesses, fabricated testimony, and hid evidence. Walter was sentenced to death and

spent six years on death row for a crime he did not commit.

But the book is not just Walter's story. It is the story of children tried as adults, of mentally ill people warehoused in prisons, of women imprisoned for stillbirths they could not control, of men executed despite the families of victims pleading for mercy. It is the story of a system that punishes poverty and calls it justice.

Stevenson's central argument is simple and radical: The opposite of poverty is not wealth. The opposite of poverty is justice. And each of us is more than the worst thing we have ever done. Mercy and justice are not opposites. They are intertwined. To see the humanity in everyone—even those who have done terrible things—is the only way to build a just society.

That lesson began with Henry, singing in a prison corridor. It continued through decades of fighting for the condemned, the forgotten, and the broken. But as Stevenson would learn again and again, the question is never simply whether justice will prevail. The real question is this: What does it take for any of us to recognize the humanity in someone the world has already condemned?

The Mockingbird Players: A False Accusation Takes Root

The phone rang in Bryan Stevenson's office. On the other end was Judge Robert E. Lee Key—named, as Stevenson would later note, after a Confederate general. The judge had heard that Stevenson planned to represent a man named Walter McMillian, a Black man on death row for the murder of a white woman. Judge Key wanted to talk him out of it.

"He's a major drug dealer," the judge said. Then he asked if Stevenson was even a member of the Alabama bar, given that he lived in Georgia. Stevenson was. The judge pushed further. Walter wasn't really poor, he argued, so he didn't need free legal services.

Stevenson didn't budge. He had already met Walter, who insisted he was innocent. Stevenson chose to believe him.

That phone call revealed something crucial. This wasn't just a case about a crime. It was about a system that had already decided Walter's fate before any evidence was heard. The judge wasn't trying to protect the legal process. He was trying to protect a conviction.

The story began years earlier, in Monroeville, Alabama—the same town where Harper Lee set *To Kill a Mockingbird*. The locals took immense pride in that novel, even building a museum to it. But Monroeville remained deeply segregated, deeply racist. The fictional tale of Tom Robinson, a Black man wrongfully convicted of raping a white woman, was celebrated as literature. The real thing was happening right now.

Walter McMillian grew up in a sharecropping family. He worked hard, started his own business, and built a life. But his marriage was unhappy, and he began an affair with a local white woman named Karen Kelly. The interracial relationship created a scandal in the small town. White residents saw it as a violation of the unwritten rules that still governed Southern life.

Then, in November 1986, an eighteen-year-old white woman named Ronda Morrison was found murdered at the dry cleaning business where she worked. The community was outraged. The police felt intense pressure to find a suspect quickly.

The investigation focused on Ralph Myers, a white man with a long criminal record and a badly disfigured face. Ralph was emotionally fragile, a tragic outcast who craved attention. He had been involved romantically with Karen Kelly—the same woman Walter was now trying to break up with. Ralph and Karen had also been implicated in the death of another white woman, Vickie Pittman.

During interrogations, Ralph said something that caught the police's attention. He claimed Walter had been involved in Vickie's murder. And then he said Walter alone had killed Ronda Morrison.

There was no evidence. Ralph couldn't even pick Walter out of a lineup. But the police had what they wanted: a suspect. A Black man who had dared to sleep with a white woman. That was enough.

Sheriff Tom Tate—who shared a surname with the fictional sheriff in *To Kill a Mockingbird*—interrogated Walter personally. He used racial slurs. He threatened him. He even referenced a lynching in Mobile that had happened just three years earlier. Walter was terrified.

The sheriff needed more than Ralph's word, though. So he found Bill Hooks, a local jailhouse snitch, who claimed he saw Walter's distinctive truck near the crime scene. Never mind that the truck hadn't been modified to look that way until months after the murder. Never mind that dozens of Black residents had seen Walter at a fish fry at the exact time of the killing. The white community reacted with joy and relief. They had their man.

Walter was arrested, charged with sodomy—a charge that allowed him to be held without bail. He was sent to death row at Holman Prison, even though he hadn't been convicted of anything. This was illegal. But the system didn't care.

Ralph Myers, watching all this unfold from his own cell, tried to recant. He told the truth: he had lied about Walter. But Sheriff Tate wouldn't allow it. Ralph was threatened, coerced, and eventually agreed to testify in exchange for being moved off death row.

The trial was moved from Monroe County, which had a large Black population, to Baldwin County, which was heavily white. The prosecutor used all his jury selection strikes to exclude every Black juror except one. Ralph's testimony was erratic and borderline nonsensical. But the jury didn't care.

Walter sat in the courtroom, watching. He couldn't believe what he was seeing. The testimony was so obviously false, so riddled with holes. He thought, Why wasn't everyone laughing?

But no one was laughing. After less than three hours of deliberation, the jury found Walter McMillian guilty of murder. He was sentenced to death.

The parallels to *To Kill a Mockingbird* were inescapable. In the novel, Tom Robinson is also convicted despite clear innocence. But in the novel, Atticus Finch fights valiantly. In the novel, the white community is supposed to learn something. In Monroeville, they built a museum to that story while ignoring the real one unfolding in their own courthouse.

Walter McMillian spent the next six years on death row for a crime he did not commit. And Judge Robert E. Lee Key's phone call to Stevenson made one thing clear: the system intended to keep him there.

Stand: Personal Encounters with Police Brutality

Late one night, Bryan Stevenson pulled into his apartment complex after a long day of work. He was exhausted. He sat in his car for a moment, listening to his favorite song on the radio—"Stand!" by Sly and the Family Stone. The music filled the small space. He noticed police cars on his block but thought nothing of it. He lived in a rough neighborhood. Police presence was normal.

He turned off the engine and opened his door.

That's when he saw the gun.

A police officer had his weapon trained directly on Stevenson's chest. The officer screamed at him to get back in the car. Another officer joined, both shouting conflicting commands. Stevenson's heart pounded. He did exactly what they said. He put his hands where they could see them. He moved slowly. He stayed calm.

They threw him against the car. They searched his vehicle illegally. They found nothing. No drugs. No weapons. No reason for any of this.

Finally, one of the officers stepped back. "We're letting you go," he said. "You should be happy."

You should be happy. The words burned into Stevenson. He had done nothing wrong. He was a Harvard-educated lawyer working to save people's lives. And yet, in that moment, he was just another Black man who had to be grateful he wasn't shot, arrested, or worse. The officer didn't see his degrees. He didn't see his work. He saw his skin.

Stevenson filed a formal complaint. He expected the system to work. Surely, someone would acknowledge what happened was wrong. Instead, he was brushed off with condescension. The officer who took his report seemed annoyed he was bothering them at all. The complaint went nowhere.

This wasn't an isolated incident. Stevenson began to see the pattern everywhere he looked. A man brought in for a traffic violation was beaten by guards and denied his asthma inhaler. He died in custody. A Black teenage boy was shot by police after running a red light. The officers claimed he was reaching for a gun. He was reaching for his driver's license. Case after case, the same story: Black bodies treated as threats, as guilty until proven innocent, as disposable.

The emotional toll was heavy. Every time Stevenson walked to his car at night, he felt the memory of that loaded gun. Every time he saw police lights, his stomach tightened. He started to understand something deeper about the system he was fighting. It wasn't just the death penalty that was broken. It was the entire apparatus—from the moment a Black person encountered law enforcement.

Stevenson decided to speak out. He began talking to youth groups, church congregations, and community organizations. He told them about the need for police accountability. He urged them to demand better. He didn't know if his words would change anything, but staying silent felt like surrender.

After one of these talks, an older man in a wheelchair approached him. The man's body was covered in scars. He lifted his shirt to show Stevenson the marks. "These are my medals of honor," he said. He had been a Civil Rights activist in the 1960s. Police dogs had mauled him. Officers had beaten him. He had survived it all. He looked at Stevenson with fierce eyes. "Beat the drum for justice," he said.

That encounter changed something in Stevenson. He realized he couldn't just file complaints and give speeches from a distance. He needed to be where the fight was hardest. He resolved to open his own office in Alabama, right in the heart of the system that was killing Black men on death row. He would name it the Equal Justice Initiative.

But first, he had to go back to Walter McMillian's case. Because while Stevenson could walk away from that police encounter, Walter could not walk away from death row.

Trials and Tribulations: A Sham Trial and a Rigged Jury

Stevenson drove to Holman Prison to meet Walter for the first time. He found a man placed on death row before his trial had even begun. This was illegal. Pretrial detainees were supposed to be held in the county jail, not a maximum-security death row facility. But the sheriff had made a decision. Walter would sit on death row and wait.

The conditions at Holman were brutal. Inmates spent twenty-three hours a day locked in tiny cells. They could see the electric chair, a yellow device the prisoners called "Yellow Mama." They heard the details of every execution from the guards and other inmates. The sounds, the smells, the way a body burned. Walter was illiterate. He couldn't write letters or file complaints. He sat in his cell and listened.

Ralph Myers was on death row too. He had been placed there after initially refusing to testify against Walter. The strategy was simple: break him. Ralph had a criminal record and a disfigured face from a childhood accident. He was emotional and frail. He craved attention. He was exactly the kind of person the system could manipulate.

When Ralph experienced his first execution from a distance, he had a mental collapse. Sheriff Tate made him an offer: testify against Walter, and get moved off death row. Ralph agreed. He gave a statement. Then he recanted. Then he was sent to a mental hospital, where doctors declared him fit to testify. He recanted again. Then he was sent back to death row. Eventually, he broke. He agreed to testify.

The trial was moved from Monroe County to Baldwin County. Monroe had a significant black population. Baldwin was heavily white. The prosecutor used every one of his jury strikes to exclude black jurors. All but one were removed. Judge Robert E. Lee Key presided over the proceedings.

Walter watched as Ralph Myers took the stand. The testimony was rambling, contradictory, almost nonsensical. Ralph couldn't keep his story straight. He changed details. He contradicted himself. He looked unstable and desperate.

Walter sat in disbelief. He looked at the jury. They were listening. They were taking notes. They were nodding.

Walter thought: Why wasn't everyone laughing?

The testimony was absurd. Anyone could see that. But the jury didn't laugh. They didn't question. They didn't hesitate. They had already decided. Walter was a black man who had slept with a white woman. He was guilty of that. The murder was just an extension.

The defense presented alibi witnesses. Multiple people had seen Walter at a fish fry at the time of the murder. The prosecution ignored them. The timeline made no sense. The physical evidence was nonexistent. None of it mattered.

After less than three hours of deliberation, the jury returned. The verdict: guilty. The sentence: death.

Walter sat in the courtroom, stunned. He had watched the proceedings with horror, expecting someone to stop the charade. No one did. Everyone seemed to be rushing to get the trial over with. The judge, the prosecutor, the jury—they all moved with purpose. They had a man to convict.

Stevenson listened to Walter describe the trial. He heard about the electric chair visible from the cell. He heard about Ralph's rambling testimony. He heard about the jury that didn't laugh.

He knew what he was up against. The system wasn't broken. It was working exactly as designed.

The Old Rugged Cross: Witnessing an Execution

In the summer of 1989, Stevenson and his friend Eva Ansley opened the Equal Justice Initiative in a small Alabama office with almost no money and almost no staff. The requests for help came immediately. Death row inmates across the state had been waiting for someone to care. The letters piled up. The phone rang constantly. Stevenson took case after case.

One of those cases was Michael Lindsey. His own attorney had written a screed calling death row inmates "mad dogs" who "ought to die." The jury had sentenced Lindsey to life, but a judge overruled them and imposed death. Stevenson argued the original sentence should stand. He was denied. Lindsey was executed.

Another client was Horace Dunkins, a man with severe intellectual disabilities. The Supreme Court would not rule the execution of mentally disabled people unconstitutional for another thirteen years. Dunkins was executed.

Then came the call about Herbert Richardson.

Herbert was a Vietnam War veteran. He had served his country and come home shattered. The war had broken something in him. He attempted suicide multiple times. He landed in a mental hospital, where he fell in love with a nurse. The relationship turned toxic. She left him and moved home to Alabama. Herbert followed her. He left a bomb on her front porch, hoping the explosion would frighten her into returning to him for protection. Instead, the bomb killed her ten-year-old niece.

Herbert was sentenced to death.

Stevenson took the case. He argued that Herbert never meant to kill anyone. The jury had been influenced by a poor defense and the prosecution's unsubstantiated claim that Herbert was a Black Muslim. His own lawyer had ignored his desire to appeal. None of it mattered. The execution date was set.

The victim's family opposed the execution. They told Stevenson, "All this grievin' is hard. We can't cheer for the man you trying to help but don't want to have to grieve for him, too. There shouldn't be no more killing behind this." Their wishes changed nothing.

Stevenson went to be with Herbert on the day of the execution. He arrived at Holman prison and met Herbert's family. They gathered in a small room. Herbert's wife was hysterical. The family was devastated. A final stay of execution was denied.

A corrections officer came to take Herbert. The officer was visibly shaken. His hands trembled. The moment was a flood of sadness and tragedy.

Herbert had made one request. As he walked to the electric chair, he wanted the hymn "The Old Rugged

Cross" to be played. The hymn about the cross—another state-sanctioned execution. Stevenson began humming it. Herbert's family joined in. Their voices filled the small room, soft and broken.

Stevenson and Herbert prayed together. Then Herbert was led away.

This was the first execution Stevenson ever witnessed. He watched every moment. He saw the guards strap Herbert into the electric chair. He saw the leather helmet placed on his head. He saw the switch thrown. He saw Herbert's body jerk and strain against the restraints. He saw the smoke rise. He saw the doctor check for a pulse and find none.

Afterward, Stevenson couldn't stop thinking about the details. "We don't spend much time contemplating the details of what killing someone actually involves," he wrote. The abstract arguments for capital punishment crumble when you watch a man die. When you hear his family weeping. When you smell the burning flesh.

Stevenson walked out of the prison into the Alabama night. He had watched the state kill a man. The man had been broken by war, broken by a system that failed him, broken by poverty and trauma. And the state's answer was to break him further.

Herbert Richardson was executed on August 18, 1989. Stevenson went home and prepared for the next case. There was always another case. Another man on death row. Another family waiting for mercy that would never come.

Surely Doomed: Children Tried as Adults

The phone rang late one night at the EJI office. An elderly woman from Virginia was on the line, her voice desperate. Her fourteen-year-old grandson, Charlie, had been in an adult jail for two days on a murder charge. She was too sick to travel, too poor to hire a lawyer. She begged Stevenson to help.

Stevenson explained that EJI focused on death penalty cases. Charlie was too young for that—the Supreme Court had recently banned executing anyone under fifteen. But the woman kept pleading. She prayed into the phone. Stevenson agreed to go see the boy.

The facts came together slowly. Charlie had killed his mother's abusive boyfriend. The boyfriend was a police officer. He had nearly beaten Charlie's mother to death. Charlie intervened. He shot the man. The prosecutor, enraged that a child had killed a cop, decided to try Charlie as an adult. They sent him to an adult county jail to await trial.

Stevenson drove to the jail. He expected to meet a scared teenager. What he found was something worse.

Charlie was tiny. He weighed less than a hundred pounds. He looked like he belonged in middle school. The guards brought him into the visiting room in handcuffs and leg irons. He sat down across from Stevenson and

stared at the floor. He wouldn't speak. He barely moved.

Stevenson tried everything. He asked about school. Nothing. He asked about the food. Nothing. He asked about the guards. Nothing. For nearly an hour, Charlie sat there, a small, silent statue. Stevenson began to panic. He couldn't reach this child. He couldn't help someone who wouldn't talk.

Then he asked a different question.

"Charlie, are you okay? Has anyone hurt you?"

The boy's face crumpled. He began to cry. The tears came hard, then harder, until his whole body shook. Stevenson waited. When Charlie finally spoke, his voice was barely a whisper.

He had been raped. Multiple times. By multiple inmates. In his first two days in adult jail, men had dragged him into a cell and done things to him that Stevenson could barely stand to hear. Charlie described it in the flat, hollow tone of a child who had already learned that adults could not protect him.

Stevenson felt sick. He had seen the worst of the system—executions, wrongful convictions, racist judges. But this was a child. A fourteen-year-old boy who had tried to protect his mother. And the state had thrown him into a cage with predators.

Stevenson got Charlie moved immediately. First to a single cell. Then to a juvenile facility. Over time, Charlie began to recover. But he was never the same. He was tormented by what he had done and what had been done to him. He carried both burdens, and neither would ever fully lift.

Charlie's grandmother died while he was in prison. His mother struggled alone. The family had nothing. Stevenson told Charlie's story at a church gathering, hoping someone might help.

After the talk, an older white couple approached him. Mr. and Mrs. Jennings. Their only grandchild had committed suicide. They had been saving for his college education. Now they wanted to give that money to help Charlie.

Stevenson was stunned. Here were two people who had lost everything—their grandchild, their dreams for him—and they chose to turn that loss into generosity for a stranger. A stranger who had killed a man.

The Jenningses paid for Charlie's GED classes. They supported his mother. They were there the day Charlie was released from prison, standing beside his mother, ready to help him start again.

But Charlie was just one child. Across the country, thousands of juveniles were being tried as adults. Many received life sentences without parole. They were sent to adult prisons where they were vulnerable to violence, rape, and permanent psychological damage. The system that claimed to protect society was destroying children.

Stevenson thought about George Stinney, a fourteen-year-old black boy executed in South Carolina in 1944. The trial lasted one day. The jury took ten minutes to convict. He weighed ninety pounds. The executioner had to adjust the electric chair because George was too small for the straps to reach.

Decades later, the laws had changed. Children could no longer be executed. But they could still be locked away forever. They could still be raped in adult prisons. They could still be treated as irredeemable monsters when their brains were not yet fully formed, when their judgment was not yet developed, when their capacity for change was still very real.

Charlie survived. He got out. He had the Jenningses. He had a second chance.

Most children in his situation did not.

Justice Denied: The Fight for a New Trial

Stevenson filed appeal after appeal. Each one was denied. The judge overseeing Walter's case was Robert E. Lee Key—named after a Confederate general, a man backed by the Ku Klux Klan. He wasn't about to overturn a conviction that had made the white community of Monroeville feel safe.

But Stevenson kept digging. He hired a new lawyer named Michael O'Connor, a first-generation American who had grown up in a rough Philadelphia neighborhood doing drugs before pulling himself together and graduating from Yale Law. Together, they found things that should have been obvious from the start.

Bill Hooks, the jailhouse snitch who claimed he saw Walter's truck near the murder scene? He'd been paid off. His own criminal charges were dropped in exchange for his testimony. And Walter's distinctive truck—the one Hooks said he recognized—hadn't even been modified until months after the murder.

Ralph Myers called Stevenson from prison. He was desperate to talk. When Stevenson visited him, Myers broke down. He explained that Sheriff Tate had coerced him into testifying against Walter. They'd threatened him with death row, bullied him, manipulated him. Now he wanted to recant. He wanted to tell the truth in court.

Stevenson and Michael followed every lead. They visited Karen Kelly in prison—the white woman Walter had been having an affair with. She confirmed that Myers and Walter had never even met. She also told them that Sheriff Tate had taunted her, called her racial slurs for sleeping with black men.

Then they looked into the other murder. Vickie Pittman. A poor white woman whose death had been all but forgotten.

Stevenson drove to see Vickie's aunts. They lived in a rural area, in a modest home. The two women were elderly, worn down by years of grief and neglect. They told Stevenson that no one had ever cared about

Vickie's murder. Not really. The police had barely investigated. The community hadn't mourned. Because Vickie was poor. She was from a family that people called "white trash."

One aunt looked at Stevenson with tired eyes. "They didn't care about her," she said. "She wasn't like that other girl."

The other girl was Ronda Morrison. The daughter of a prominent family. The murder that had sparked outrage, that had demanded a suspect, that had put an innocent man on death row. Vickie Pittman was just as dead. Her family had just as much right to justice. But class determined whose life mattered. Race too. The system valued some victims and ignored others.

The aunts told Stevenson something else. They'd heard rumors that Vickie's own father might have been involved in her murder. And the local sheriff. The same sheriff who had helped build the case against Walter.

Stevenson filed a Rule 32 petition—a post-conviction appeal that would allow them to present all this new evidence. To their surprise, the Alabama Supreme Court approved it. They granted Stevenson access to the full criminal files, including Sheriff Tate's records, the psychiatric hospital where Myers had been held, and the Pittman murder files from the neighboring county.

The hostility was immediate. Sheriff Tate and District Attorney Chapman made their anger clear. Then the bomb threats started. Someone called the EJI office, threatening to blow it up. Then another call. Then another. Three threats in two months. There were threatening phone calls, racist letters. Stevenson's staff kept working. They had no choice.

Stevenson thought about Vickie Pittman's aunts. Their grief had been invisible. Their niece's murder had been treated as an inconvenience, something to sweep under the rug while the town focused on the "real" victim. The pursuit of justice for Walter meant uncovering these forgotten crimes too. It meant acknowledging that the system didn't just fail the accused. It failed the victims it deemed unworthy.

And it meant confronting the truth that some people's lives counted for more than others. Not because of what they'd done, but because of who they were. Poor. Rural. Easy to ignore.

The aunts had given Stevenson something precious. Not just information about Vickie's murder, but a window into how class and race intersect to determine whose suffering matters. Walter's case wasn't just about one innocent man on death row. It was about a system that sorted human beings into categories—valuable and worthless, worthy of justice and deserving of neglect.

Stevenson carried that understanding with him as he prepared for the next fight. The hearing that would finally give Walter a chance to prove his innocence. The hearing that would force the system to look at what it had done.

Mitigation: Mental Illness and the Prison Warehouse

Stevenson began to notice a pattern in his cases. So many of his clients were mentally ill. They weren't criminals in the traditional sense—they were sick people who had been locked away because society didn't know what else to do with them.

The history was clear. In the nineteenth century, activists like Dorothea Dix had fought to move the mentally ill out of prisons and into hospitals. For a time, it worked. But by the mid-twentieth century, those hospitals had become warehouses of their own, places where abuse flourished. A new generation of activists demanded deinstitutionalization. People who hadn't committed crimes couldn't be held against their will, they argued. The mentally ill deserved freedom.

They got it. But freedom without support meant something else entirely. Thousands of mentally ill people ended up on the streets. And when they acted out—when their illness drove them to break the law—the police picked them up. The prisons became the new asylums. By the time Stevenson started practicing, America's jails and prisons held more mentally ill people than all the psychiatric hospitals in the country combined.

One of Stevenson's clients was George Daniel. George had suffered a traumatic brain injury in a car accident. After that, he started hallucinating. His behavior became erratic and frightening. Before his family could get him proper medical help, he fled on a bus. He ended up in a scuffle with an armed policeman. The policeman was killed. A doctor named Ed Seger examined George and declared he was "malingering"—faking his psychosis. George was sentenced to death. Years later, it came out that Dr. Seger had faked his credentials. For eight years, he'd been practicing without a license.

Then there was Avery Jenkins.

Stevenson drove to the prison to meet Avery for the first time. In the parking lot, he noticed a pickup truck covered in Confederate flag bumper stickers and racist slogans. Inside, a guard stopped him. The guard ordered Stevenson to strip for a search—a violation of prison policy. Stevenson complied, humiliated. The guard who conducted the search owned that truck.

When Stevenson finally sat down with Avery, he could see immediately how sick the man was. Avery had committed murder during a psychotic episode. He couldn't assist in his own defense. He couldn't focus on the legal questions Stevenson needed to ask. Instead, he kept asking about one thing: getting a chocolate milkshake.

At Avery's hearing, Stevenson presented the full story of Avery's life. The abuse he'd suffered in foster care. The trauma that had shaped him. The mental illness that had gone untreated for years. Stevenson told the court that expecting Avery to function normally without help was like expecting a man without legs to climb

stairs.

The guard with the Confederate flag bumper stickers was assigned to escort Avery to the hearings. Day after day, he sat in the courtroom and listened. He heard about Avery's childhood. He heard about the foster care system that had failed him. He heard about the abuse that had broken him.

One day, after the hearing, the guard approached Stevenson. His demeanor had changed completely. He was no longer hostile. He seemed almost sheepish.

"I was in foster care too," the guard said. "I was abused too."

He paused. Then he said something Stevenson never expected.

"I bought Avery a chocolate milkshake on the way home."

The guard had heard Avery asking for one. So he stopped and bought it for him.

Stevenson eventually succeeded in moving Avery off death row and into a mental health facility where he could receive proper treatment. Later, Stevenson heard that the guard had quit his job at the prison.

The guard's transformation wasn't just about Avery. It was about what happens when we allow ourselves to see the humanity in people we've dismissed. The guard had spent years hating prisoners—hating black men like Stevenson and Avery. But when he heard Avery's story, he recognized something of himself. The walls came down.

That's what mercy does. It breaks through the barriers we build. It connects us to people we thought were nothing like us. And sometimes, it changes everything.

I'm Here: The Hearing and the Power of Community

The date for Walter McMillian's hearing had finally arrived. After years of appeals, delays, and denials, Stevenson and his colleague Michael O'Connor had somehow convinced the court to reconsider Walter's case. But the odds were still against them. The new judge, Norton, was already tired of the case. And their star witness was Ralph Myers—the same man who had lied on the stand to put Walter on death row.

They spent days preparing Myers for testimony. He was erratic, fragile, and unpredictable. Stevenson wasn't sure the judge would believe him. But they had no other choice.

On the first morning of the hearing, something unexpected happened. Walter's entire community showed up. Friends, family, neighbors—they filled the parking lot, the hallways, the benches outside the courtroom. They had come to support a man they knew was innocent. Stevenson could see that this irritated District Attorney Chapman and Sheriff Tate. They had expected Walter to face this alone.

Myers took the stand. And something shifted. His testimony was direct, persuasive, and credible. He told the court that everything he had said at trial was a lie. He described how Sheriff Tate had threatened him, coerced him, promised to move him off death row if he testified against Walter. Judge Norton leaned forward. He was listening now.

The second day, Stevenson arrived to find the courtroom transformed. A metal detector stood at the entrance. And beside it, a German Shepherd police dog. The benches inside were filled with white people. Walter's black supporters were barred from entering.

Stevenson was furious. He complained to the court. Some supporters were eventually allowed through. But then he saw Mrs. Williams.

She was an older black woman, small and quiet. She stood at the entrance, frozen. Her eyes were fixed on the police dog. She couldn't move. Stevenson went to her. She told him she had been attacked by police dogs during the Civil Rights march in Selma in 1965. The memory was still raw. The fear was still real.

During the morning testimony, Myers' caretakers from the psychiatric facility confirmed his story. They testified that Sheriff Tate had pressured them, threatened them, manipulated Myers into lying. The evidence was mounting. But Stevenson kept thinking about Mrs. Williams in the parking lot.

The next day, she was back. She walked past the police dog. She didn't run. She didn't flinch. She walked straight into the courtroom, found a seat, and looked at Stevenson. "I'm here," she said.

Those two words carried the weight of decades. Of Selma. Of every courtroom where black people had been turned away. Of every trial where justice had been denied. Mrs. Williams was not just showing up for Walter. She was showing up for everyone who had been told they didn't belong.

The third day brought the most damning evidence. Stevenson played the original interrogation tape of Ralph Myers. On that tape, you could hear Sheriff Tate and others threatening Myers, coercing him, feeding him the story they wanted him to tell. The tape proved what Stevenson had argued all along: the case against Walter was built on lies. The prosecution had never provided this tape to Walter's original attorney. That alone was illegal.

The district attorney chose not to rebut the evidence. He had nothing to say.

By then, the national media had taken notice. 60 Minutes had aired a segment on Walter's case. The Washington Post had published articles. The pressure was building. The system that had locked Walter away for six years was beginning to crack.

Judge Norton asked both sides to submit written briefs. He would make his decision later. But Stevenson could feel the momentum shifting. It wasn't just the legal arguments. It was the community. It was Mrs. Williams walking past that dog. It was the quiet courage of people who refused to let an innocent man die

alone.

The hearing ended. But something had changed. Walter's freedom was no longer a distant hope. It was becoming inevitable.

Broken: The Enduring Need for Mercy

The hearing ended. The momentum shifted. But justice, Stevenson was learning, never moves in a straight line.

Judge Norton took months to rule. When he finally did, he denied the appeal. The same system that had locked Walter away for six years wasn't ready to let him go. But Stevenson had already taken Walter's case public. 60 Minutes had aired their segment. The Washington Post had published their articles. The pressure was building.

The Alabama Court of Appeals agreed to hear the case. Six weeks later, they issued their ruling: Walter McMillian's conviction was invalid. His death sentence was thrown out.

Stevenson rushed to Holman Prison. He found Walter in his cell, confused, unable to process what was happening. When Stevenson told him he was going home, Walter didn't cheer. He didn't celebrate. He sat in silence, thinking about all the time he had lost. All the years stolen from him. All the friends he would leave behind on death row.

The next day, Walter walked out of prison a free man.

But freedom didn't heal everything. Walter had nightmares. He grieved for the men still locked up. He received no compensation from the state of Alabama. Sheriff Tate kept telling people Walter was guilty. Tate kept getting re-elected. He's sheriff to this day.

Walter tried to rebuild. He traveled with Stevenson, speaking to law students, telling his story. He wasn't angry or bitter, he said. But the trauma had carved something out of him. His health began to fail. He became forgetful. He wandered without destination. The diagnosis came back: advancing dementia.

Stevenson found Walter a short-term care facility. When he visited, Walter was cheerful at first. Then panic set in. He thought the hospital was death row. He begged Stevenson to save him. Stevenson calmed him down, but something had broken in both of them.

As Stevenson left the facility, shaken and disturbed, his phone rang. A client named Jimmy Dill was about to be executed. Stevenson had tried everything. Nothing had worked.

That night, Stevenson called Jimmy on the phone. And as he listened to Jimmy's voice, he remembered something from his own childhood. A boy with a stutter. Young Bryan had laughed at him. His mother had

ordered Bryan to hug the boy and say, "I love you." When Bryan did, trembling with shame, the boy had replied, "I love you too."

Now Jimmy Dill said the same thing. "I love you too."

Stevenson realized: he had received mercy he didn't deserve. From the boy with the stutter. From Jimmy Dill. From people who had every reason to be angry but chose kindness instead.

Jimmy Dill was executed that night. Stevenson drove home broken-hearted. But he kept working. There was more work to do.

In 2010, the Supreme Court ruled that life without parole for children convicted of non-homicide crimes was unconstitutional. Two years later, they extended that ruling to homicide cases. Stevenson's clients, men who had been locked up as children and grown into thoughtful, remorseful adults, became eligible for release. The science was clear: adolescents lack the maturity and future orientation to be held to adult standards. Mercy, Stevenson argued, was not weakness. It was recognizing the truth of human development.

But the system pushed back. At Angola prison, once a slave plantation, now a brutal work camp, Stevenson fought to free two elderly men who had been sentenced as children. Decades of hard labor had left them disabled. They were finally released. After one hearing, an older black woman approached Stevenson in the courthouse. She wasn't involved with either case. Her grandson had been murdered by two teenage boys. Their life sentences had only wounded her more. Now she came to the courthouse to support families of both victims and perpetrators. She called herself a "stonecatcher," after the Bible story where Jesus stops a stoning and tells the crowd to examine their own sins before throwing stones. She offered Stevenson a peppermint candy. He took it.

Walter McMillian died in September 2013. He spent his last years living with his sister Katie, kind and charming until the very end. He died on God's schedule, not the government's. That mattered to Stevenson.

At Walter's funeral, Stevenson stood before the crowd of mourners. Most were poor. Most were black. They had come to say goodbye to a man who had been stolen from them, then given back, then taken again by time and trauma.

Stevenson spoke about what Walter had taught him. About mercy. About hope. He told them that "mercy is just when it is rooted in hopefulness and freely given." Walter had mercy for the people who framed him. For the sheriff who lied. For the judge who looked the other way. That mercy, freely given to undeserving people, was what allowed Walter to recover a life worth celebrating.

Stevenson thought about all the broken people he had met. The children tried as adults. The mentally ill locked in prison warehouses. The innocent men on death row. The women convicted for miscarriages they couldn't control. The guards who learned to see humanity in the people they guarded. The families who

grieved for both victims and perpetrators.

We are all broken by something, Stevenson wrote. We all share the condition of brokenness, even if our brokenness is not equivalent. The question is not whether we are broken. The question is what we do with that knowledge.

Do we throw stones? Or do we catch them?

Stevenson kept working. The Equal Justice Initiative kept fighting. Executions in Alabama decreased. More prisoners were released. More children were given second chances. But the work never ended. There were always more cases, more clients, more families waiting for justice.

Stevenson thought about Mrs. Williams, who had walked past the police dog. About the stonecatcher woman with her peppermint candy. About Walter, who died free. About Jimmy Dill, who said "I love you too." About every broken person who had shown him that mercy was possible.

The opposite of poverty is not wealth, Stevenson believed. The opposite of poverty is justice. And justice, real justice, requires mercy. Not mercy for the deserving. Mercy for the undeserving. Mercy for the broken. Mercy for the people we want to throw stones at.

Because we are all broken. And we all need mercy.